

Contradictory Chronicles: Indigenous Self-Portraits and External Narratives Before 1700

Indigenous Self-Representation: The Creation of Internal Worldviews

Before 1700, indigenous communities across the globe developed sophisticated systems of expression to articulate their histories, cosmologies, and social structures, often creating records intended primarily for internal consumption. These self-representations provide a crucial counterpoint to external accounts, revealing worldviews that were complex, internally coherent, and not necessarily designed for foreign comprehension. The materials indicate that these records took several distinct forms, including intricate pictorial manuscripts, foundational mythological texts, and enduring oral traditions preserved by specialized knowledge-holders. The very act of creating these documents was an assertion of identity and a method of preserving cultural continuity against the pressures of external forces. In Mesoamerica, the Mixtec people produced screenfold codices that served as detailed genealogical and historical chronicles ⁵⁵. These works, such as the Codex Vindobonensis Mexicanus I, were written in symbols and pictures, functioning as legal and dynastic records that traced the lineage and military exploits of city-states ^{37 57 84}. The meticulous detail in these manuscripts, which could document events over centuries, demonstrates a deep-seated need to preserve a collective memory and legitimize political authority within the community ⁷⁴. Similarly, the K'iche' Maya's Popol Vuh stands as a monumental example of cultural self-definition, narrating the creation of the world and humanity through a distinctly indigenous cosmological lens ¹¹. Modern scholars now assume that copies of this pre-Columbian text survived the conquest, indicating its profound importance to the K'iche' people's sense of identity and history ²¹.

In the Andes, while less detailed information is provided, the work of Felipe Guaman Poma de Ayala emerges as a powerful act of indigenous self-representation in a colonial context ⁶¹. His magnum opus, *Nueva corónica y buen gobierno*, represents a direct intervention in the historical record, authored by an indigenous intellectual who sought

to present an alternative Andean perspective on the conquest and its aftermath 25 26 . By undertaking the formidable task of mastering the tools of Spanish literacy, Guaman Poma aimed to create a comprehensive history that centered his people's experience, challenging the dominant European narrative 62 107. His work exemplifies how indigenous intellectuals navigated the "contact zone" to produce texts that were both responses to and critiques of colonialism 61 . In West Africa, the tradition of the griot functioned as the primary vehicle for oral historical transmission 22 . Griots were responsible for memorizing and reciting genealogies, recounting the deeds of ancestors, and preserving the laws and customs of their people, effectively serving as living archives for Mandinka and other societies 20 . The reconstruction of West African history relies heavily on combining sparse European narrative sources with the rich data furnished by these oral traditions 68 98 . This methodology acknowledges oral tradition not as mere folklore but as a rigorous system of historical record-keeping 60 . The Ainu of northern Japan, who did not develop a formal writing system until much later, preserved their history, mythology, and spiritual beliefs through epic poems known as *yukar* 59 94 . These oral narratives, which were meticulously recorded by modern ethnographers, reflect early trade relations with the Japanese and contain commentary on those interactions, demonstrating the dynamic and reflective nature of their oral tradition 69 . These diverse examples—from pictorial codices and sacred texts to oral epics and griotic histories—underscore a fundamental human drive to create and maintain a coherent internal record of existence. These sources portray a world defined by intricate kinship systems, a deep connection to the land, complex spiritual beliefs, and a long history of political organization and cultural achievement. They represent a baseline of indigenous self-perception, predating and existing alongside the flood of external interpretations that would follow.

Culture/Region	Form of Self-Representation	Primary Function/Purpose
Mesoamerican (Mixtec)	Pictorial Codices (e.g., Codex Vindobonensis Mexicanus I) 37	Genealogical and historical record; legitimization of political authority 55
Mesoamerican (K'iche')	Mythological Text (Popol Vuh)	Cultural and cosmological self-definition; creation narrative 11 21
Andean	Historical Chronicle (Guaman Poma's Nueva corónica y buen gobierno) 25	Alternative historical account; critique of Spanish conquest and colonialism 26 61
West African (Mandinka)	Oral Tradition (Griot Narrative) 22	Preservation of genealogy, law, custom, and communal history 20 68
East Asian (Ainu)	Oral Epic Poetry (<i>Yukar</i>) 59	Transmission of mythology, history, spiritual beliefs, and cultural values 69 94

External Perceptions: Colonial, Imperial, and Traveler Narratives

External portrayals of indigenous peoples before 1700 were overwhelmingly shaped by the perspectives, agendas, and cultural frameworks of the observers. These accounts, spanning from imperial Chinese records to Spanish colonial chronicles and transcontinental travelogues, reveal a wide spectrum of perceptions, ranging from pragmatic observation to outright dehumanization. A central theme is the use of these portrayals to justify political and economic actions, particularly in the context of expanding empires. Spanish conquistadors and jurists frequently justified their campaigns of conquest by arguing that indigenous peoples were subhuman or irrational beings without souls, thereby denying them the rights afforded to Christians ⁹⁰. This ideological stance was used to rationalize the seizure of land and labor. However, this view was contested within the Christian world itself. In 1537, Pope Paul III issued the papal bull *Sublimis Deus*, which explicitly condemned the doctrine of Indian subhumanity, declaring that indigenous peoples possessed liberty and should not be enslaved ⁵¹. This decree represented a significant theological and moral challenge to the prevailing justifications for conquest, affirming the humanity of indigenous populations even as enforcement remained a major problem ⁵¹. Another prominent example of external portrayal comes from Ibn Battuta, the 14th-century Moroccan traveler. During his visit to the Mali Empire, he expressed disapproval of what he perceived as the immodesty of Muslim women, reflecting his own cultural norms rather than an objective assessment of Malian society ⁷⁶. His writings, along with those of other Arab and Persian travelers, offer valuable insights into the kingdoms of West Africa but must be read critically, acknowledging the observer's inherent biases ^{18 89}. In East Asia, Ming Dynasty Chinese records, such as the *Shilu* (Veritable Records), documented various ethnic groups under imperial administration, like the Jianzhou Jurchens ¹¹⁰¹¹¹. These official histories served to reinforce the hierarchical structure of the empire and legitimize Ming rule over its diverse subjects, portraying interactions through the lens of imperial authority and tribute ¹¹². These varied external accounts demonstrate that portrayals were rarely neutral; they were instruments used to define relationships of power, justify expansion, and construct an image of the "other" that served the needs of the observer's own society.

The table below illustrates the diversity of external portrayals and their underlying motivations.

Source/Author	Origin/Culture	Portrayal of Indigenous Peoples	Stated Purpose/Motivation
Spanish Conquistadors & Jurists	Spanish Empire	Subhuman, irrational, lacking souls; suitable for enslavement.	Justification for conquest, land seizure, and forced labor. 90
Pope Paul III (<i>Sublimis Deus</i> , 1537)	Roman Catholic Church	Fully human, possessing liberty and property rights; should not be enslaved.	Moral and theological justification for humane treatment; challenge to conquest ideology. 51
Ibn Battuta	Arab (Moroccan)	Subject to personal cultural judgment (e.g., female modesty); part of a thriving Islamic empire.	Personal travelogue documenting his journey and observations of foreign lands. 76 89
Ming Dynasty Historians (<i>Ming Shilu</i>)	Ming China	Subjects of the empire; documented through the lens of tribute and administration.	Legitimization of imperial authority and consolidation of the state. 110 111 112
Baltasar Jaime Martínez Compañón	Spanish Empire (Peru)	Object of scientific and religious study; focus on documenting native life and potential for conversion.	Collection of ethnographic and natural history data for the Spanish crown. 13

The Nature of Pre-1700 Written and Oral Records

The investigation into pre-1700 portrayals necessitates a broad definition of "text," one that moves beyond the linear, alphabetic model prevalent in Europe. The provided sources reveal a rich and varied landscape of textual production, including highly structured pictorial and hieroglyphic systems, sophisticated non-literate oral traditions, and hybrid documents born from cross-cultural contact. Understanding the medium itself is critical, as it profoundly influences the message conveyed. In Mesoamerica, indigenous scribes developed complex picture-writing systems where books were composed of symbols and pictures to convey historical events, genealogies, and calendrical information [57](#) [81](#) [84](#). Codices like the Borgia and the Vindobonensis Mexicanus I are testaments to a visual language capable of expressing abstract concepts and complex narratives [37](#) [65](#). These were not primitive precursors to writing but mature literary forms used for specific cultural purposes [97](#). Similarly, in the Andes, ethnohistoric sources suggest that a form of recording existed, though its exact nature is less clear than its Mesoamerican counterpart [48](#). The Ainu, despite lacking a formal writing system until the early modern period, maintained a vibrant literary tradition through their *yukar* oral epics, which were analyzed by modern linguists to create the first part-of-speech tagger for the Ainu language, proving the linguistic complexity of their unwritten literature [59](#) [94](#). This highlights the necessity of methodologies that can analyze and validate oral traditions as rigorous historical records, a practice essential to reconstructing African history from the limited European sources [68](#) [98](#). The most unique category of texts

emerged in the colonial "contact zone," where indigenous and European traditions merged. The Florentine Codex, compiled by the Franciscan Bernardino de Sahagún with the help of Nahua elders, is the quintessential example of this hybridity [46](#) [58](#) . It is a massive encyclopedia of Aztec life, written in Nahuatl and translated into Latin and Spanish, representing a complex process of translation across languages and cultural frameworks [58](#) [91](#) . While invaluable, it also reflects the tensions of its creation, as Sahagún organized the material to facilitate Christian conversion, sometimes imposing structures foreign to the original Nahua worldview [63](#) [92](#) . These hybrid texts, alongside indigenous-authored works like Guaman Poma's *Nueva corónica*, demonstrate that literacy in the colonial era was a contested space where meaning was negotiated and reinterpreted [61](#) . The survival of these diverse records is remarkable, given the widespread destruction of indigenous texts during colonization. The journey of the Mixtec Codex Vindobonensis Mexicanus I from its origin in Mexico to Spain and finally to Vienna underscores the chaotic preservation of these artifacts [73](#) [74](#) . Many such works were undoubtedly lost, leaving a historical record that is inherently fragmented and biased towards what European powers chose to save or deemed useful.

Conflict and Coercion: Portrayals of Conquest, Resistance, and Dehumanization

Conflict and coercion represent the most pervasive and consequential theme in the portrayal of indigenous interactions before 1700, particularly in the wake of European expansion. These portrayals are deeply polarized, reflecting the irreconcilable perspectives of conquerors seeking justification and conquered peoples asserting agency in the face of annihilation. The Spanish conquest of the Americas provides the most stark illustration of this dichotomy. On one side, Spanish conquistadors and jurists articulated a worldview that required the dehumanization of indigenous peoples to legitimize their violent actions [90](#) . They framed their campaigns not as acts of aggression but as necessary interventions to bring civilization and Christianity to allegedly barbaric and idolatrous peoples [90](#) . This ideological framework was used to support policies like the *encomienda* system, which effectively reduced native populations to a labor force [51](#) . The arrival of the Spaniards in Peru, for instance, was seen by some Andean peoples not as a catastrophe but as an opportunity to rebel against their oppressive Inka overlords, a complex dynamic that reshaped local power structures [75](#) . Conversely, indigenous portrayals of this period are characterized by trauma, loss, and a fierce assertion of resilience. The creation of texts like Guaman Poma's *Nueva corónica y buen gobierno* was,

in part, a response to this violence, a desperate attempt to preserve a history that colonial authorities were actively trying to erase [25](#) [26](#). Even within the colonizing camp, this ideology faced opposition. The papal bulls of Paul III, especially *Sublimis Deus*, stand as a powerful, if often unenforced, ecclesiastical rebuke to the doctrine of indigenous subhumanity, affirming their right to freedom and property [51](#). This internal Christian debate reveals the ideological battleground over the very nature of indigenous humanity. Beyond the Americas, other instances of conflict are documented. The Khoisan peoples of southern Africa are noted for their resistance to Dutch settlers in the 17th and 18th centuries, with materials for West African history preserved in Portuguese archives providing evidence of such encounters [105](#). In Ming China, official histories recorded military campaigns against various ethnic groups, portraying them as rebellious subjects who needed to be subdued to maintain imperial order [110](#). These varied accounts of conflict all share a common thread: the portrayal is inseparable from the power relationship. The victor's narrative typically frames the event as a righteous action, while the vanquished's memory is preserved in texts of lament, resistance, and cultural endurance.

Exchange and Interaction: Trade, Diplomacy, and Cultural Synthesis

While conflict dominated the narrative of many pre-1700 encounters, the provided sources also illuminate more nuanced forms of interaction, including trade, diplomacy, and cultural exchange. These relationships, though often asymmetrical, demonstrate that interactions were not solely defined by violence and coercion. In East Asia, the relationship between the Ainu of northern Japan and the surrounding Japanese state was marked by a long history of contact that helped spur the formation of a distinct Japanese identity [78](#). Ainu oral traditions, specifically the *kamui yukar*, reflect on these early interactions, containing commentary on trade with the Japanese mainland, indicating a sustained economic and cultural relationship that predated the full incorporation of Ainu territory into the Japanese state [69](#). This suggests a dynamic where indigenous peoples were active participants in regional economies and political formations. In West Africa, the Mali Empire, under rulers like Sundiata Keita and Mansa Musa, became a hub of trans-Saharan trade, connecting regions of the continent and fostering diplomatic and commercial ties with North Africa and the wider Islamic world [20](#) [35](#). The presence of foreign sailors and merchants, and the subsequent documentation of these contacts in European records, points to a history of engagement that was multifaceted [98](#) [104](#). The

ultimate example of forced cultural exchange is the creation of the Florentine Codex in 16th-century Mexico ⁴⁶. Commissioned by the Franciscan friar Bernardino de Sahagún, this monumental work involved Nahua elders and scribes translating their vast body of knowledge—including astronomy, botany, zoology, religion, and daily life—into a format accessible to Europeans ^{91 103}. This was a profound act of syncretism, where indigenous knowledge was systematically extracted and translated, albeit for the purpose of facilitating conversion ⁶³. The resulting text is a palimpsest of two worlds, containing layers of Nahua thought, Spanish interpretation, and Franciscan theology ⁵⁸. While the process was fundamentally unequal, with the final product serving the goals of the Spanish mission, it nonetheless represents a unique moment of intense intellectual and spiritual exchange ³⁰. These examples show that alongside conflict, there were sustained patterns of trade, diplomacy, and cultural negotiation. These interactions were often shaped by power imbalances, but they nonetheless created spaces for the sharing of ideas, goods, and technologies, leaving a legacy of hybrid cultures and complex interdependencies.

Synthesis of Portrayals and Analytical Limitations

The comparative analysis of pre-1700 oral histories and documented texts reveals a landscape of profoundly divergent portrayals of indigenous peoples. At the core lies a fundamental duality: the internal self-representation crafted by indigenous communities for their own purposes, and the external portrayal constructed by observers—be they colonial administrators, imperial historians, or traveling merchants—for theirs. Indigenous sources, whether pictorial codices, sacred myths, or griot narratives, consistently present a worldview characterized by complex political structures, rich spiritual lives, and a deep sense of historical continuity ^{11 22 55}. In stark contrast, many external accounts, particularly those justifying conquest, depict indigenous peoples as either noble savages or subhuman obstacles to progress, a binary that served to legitimize dispossession and violence ^{51 90}. The most compelling evidence of this clash of perspectives is found in the hybrid texts of the colonial "contact zone." Works like the Florentine Codex and Guaman Poma's *Nueva corónica y buen gobierno* are palimpsests of competing worldviews, simultaneously preserving invaluable indigenous knowledge and filtering it through a European lens ^{58 61}. These documents are not merely sources of information; they are artifacts of a collision of civilizations, where meaning was contested and renegotiated. Despite these rich sources, a comprehensive understanding is constrained by significant analytical limitations. There is a pronounced geographic bias in

the available materials, with the Americas (specifically Mesoamerica and the Andes) receiving the most detailed attention ¹ ⁵³. Accounts from Australia, Siberia, and much of Sub-Saharan Africa remain underrepresented, relying on general references to oral traditions rather than specific, well-documented texts ³⁸ ⁶⁷. Furthermore, there is a temporal skew towards the post-contact period. Information about indigenous portrayals before the 15th century, outside of brief mentions of Arab travelers like Ibn Battuta, is scarce ⁸⁹. Finally, the historical record is inherently fragmented. The systematic destruction of indigenous texts during colonization means that what survives is a small fraction of what once existed, and much of it was filtered through the interests of those who preserved it ²¹ ⁷³. Therefore, any portrait of the pre-1700 world must be understood as partial and contingent, a mosaic pieced together from sources whose very existence is a testament to a turbulent and transformative era.

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